Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 35

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes
Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [ ] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: An astronaut describes her first morning back on Earth after six months on the International Space Station.

1
The teacup, when I lifted it, almost broke my wrist. I had not expected that. The cup was the same blue china cup I had drunk from a hundred times before, in this same small kitchen, with its scratched table and its single south-facing window; and yet, that first morning home, it weighed as much as a stone. I set it back down very carefully and looked at my own hand, surprised by it, as though it belonged to someone else.

2
For six months I had floated. I had pushed off a wall and drifted, slow and exact, to the other end of a module; I had slept tethered to a ceiling; I had eaten food that hovered, in obedient little spheres, an inch from the spoon. Gravity, up there, had been a memory, a thing other people talked about. Now it was everywhere — in my elbows, in my eyelids, in the soft, unfamiliar pull at the base of my spine when I tried, foolishly, to stand up too quickly. I had been warned about this. None of the warnings had quite prepared me.

3
Outside the window, the birds were impossibly loud. I had forgotten birds. There were two of them in the small camphor tree across the lane, arguing in clean, bright bursts about something I could not understand and would never need to. On the station, sound had been a constant low hum — fans, pumps, the steady breath of the life-support system — and against that hum, human voices had been the only sharpness. Here, on Earth, the world itself was sharp. A car door slammed three streets away and I flinched.

4
I caught sight of myself in the dark glass of the microwave: a woman with cropped, untidy hair and a face that looked, somehow, both older and younger than I remembered. Older in the small lines around

the eyes, which I supposed were the gift of half a year of unfiltered sunlight through a window the size of a dinner plate. Younger in the expression — startled, attentive, a little undone — as though I were a child again, looking at a kitchen for the first time. I did not know, just then, which version of myself to greet.

5
My husband, sensible man, had left me alone for an hour. He had put the kettle on, kissed the top of my head, and gone to the shops. He understood, I think, that there were certain reunions that could not be rushed: not the reunion with him, which we had managed in the small hours of the morning at the airport, but the quieter, stranger reunion with the ordinary world — with crockery, with the smell of toast, with the way the light falls on a wooden floor at half past eight.

6
I picked up the cup again, more carefully this time, with both hands. I drank the tea slowly. It tasted, I thought, the way tea is supposed to taste, which is to say, of nothing remarkable: of warm water and leaves and a little milk. And yet I almost wept into it, because nothing remarkable, after six months of remarkable, is the most extraordinary thing in the world.

7
I thought, then, of the Earth as I had last seen it from above — that blue, patient curve, wrapped in its thin and improbable skin of weather. I had not, up there, been able to stop looking at it. I had not, up there, quite believed I belonged to it. Now, in a quiet kitchen on a Tuesday morning, with a heavy cup of perfectly ordinary tea in my hands and a bird arguing in a tree, I understood that I did. I belonged to this. And I knew, with a calm that surprised me, that I would not be quite the same woman in it as I had been when I left.

8
The kettle clicked off behind me, finished. Outside, the second bird answered the first. I sat in my own kitchen, in my own gravity, and I waited, with no impatience at all, for my husband to come home.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says the teacup "almost broke my wrist." Explain, in your own words, what this **exaggeration** tells us about her physical condition on her first morning home. [**2**]

2. The narrator looks at her own hand "as though it belonged to someone else." What does this suggest about how she is feeling? [**1**]

From Paragraph 2

3. In Paragraph 2, the narrator says that gravity "had been a memory, a thing other people talked about." Explain what this suggests about her experience of life on the space station. [**2**]

4. Give **two** details from Paragraph 2 that show that gravity is now affecting the narrator's body. [**2**]

From Paragraph 3

5. The narrator says she "had forgotten birds." What does this short sentence suggest about how her time in space has changed her? [**2**]

6. Explain how the language in Paragraph 3 **contrasts** the sound of the space station with the sound of Earth. Support your answer with **two** details from the paragraph. [**3**]

From Paragraph 4

7. The narrator describes her own face as looking "both older and younger" than she remembered.
(a) What does she mean by "older"? [**1**]
(b) What does she mean by "younger"? [**1**]

From Paragraph 5

8. The narrator calls her husband a "sensible man" for leaving her alone for an hour. Why does she consider this sensible? [**2**]

From Paragraph 6

9. The narrator says the tea tasted "of nothing remarkable" and yet she "almost wept into it." Explain this apparent contradiction. [**2**]

From Paragraph 7

10. The narrator describes the Earth from space as wrapped in "its thin and improbable skin of weather." What does the word **improbable** suggest about her view of the Earth? [**1**]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final paragraph of the text? [**1**]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on the push to mine the deep seabed for metals.

1

Four kilometres below the surface of the Pacific Ocean, in a darkness no sunlight has ever reached, the seabed is paved with what look, at first glance, like potatoes. They are called polymetallic nodules, and they are extraordinary little objects. Each one is the slow, patient handiwork of millions of years, growing a few millimetres every million years from minerals that drift down through the cold water and settle around a tiny grain of sand or a fragment of shark tooth. Inside each nodule, in concentrations that put many land mines to shame, lie cobalt, nickel, copper and manganese — the exact metals upon which the modern electric battery, and therefore the modern clean-energy transition, increasingly depends.

2

This coincidence has not gone unnoticed. A handful of mining companies, working in partnership with small island states that hold the legal rights to the relevant patches of seabed, are now pressing for permission to begin commercial extraction. Their case is straightforward. To meet the climate targets that governments have already signed up to, the world will need, by 2040, several times the cobalt and nickel it currently produces. Land-based supplies are concentrated in a small number of countries, are politically fraught, and, in the case of cobalt, are linked to documented abuses in artisanal mines. The deep seabed, the companies argue, is the cleanest, fairest, and least exploited source available — a way of greening one industry without poisoning another.

3

Against this case stands a coalition of marine scientists, conservation groups and an increasing number of national governments who consider deep-sea mining a profound mistake. The seabed, they point out, is not a parking lot. It is one of the largest and least understood ecosystems on the planet. A single square metre of the nodule fields supports a thicket of strange and slow-living creatures — glass sponges, ghost-white octopuses, transparent worms — many of which have never been formally described. To scoop up the nodules is, in effect, to scrape the surface of that world bare. Recovery, on the timescales that matter to a human life, is measured not in years but in centuries, if it happens at all.

4

The harm, moreover, would not be confined to the immediate footprint of the machinery. A nodule collector, in operation, throws up a vast plume of fine sediment, which then drifts for tens of kilometres in the currents before falling, like a slow grey snow, on creatures that have evolved in some of the clearest water on Earth. The waste water pumped back overboard from the surface ship carries its own plume into the mid-water column, where it threatens fish that the global tuna industry depends on. A 2023 review in the journal **Nature** concluded that, on present evidence, the ecological costs of even a modest mining operation were “almost certainly underestimated, and possibly catastrophic.”

5

Sitting awkwardly between these two camps is the International Seabed Authority, a little-known body established under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea. The Authority, headquartered in Kingston, Jamaica, has the curious double mandate of both **regulating** deep-sea mining and **promoting** it as a benefit to “all mankind.” Critics have long argued that this is a conflict of interest baked into the institution itself. Supporters reply that the Authority is at least a forum, with rules and a register of contractors, and that without it the seabed would be even more vulnerable to a free-for-all.

6

What the Authority does next will matter very much. As of 2024, more than two dozen exploration contracts had been issued, covering an area of seabed larger than the territory of India. Yet the mining code — the detailed set of rules that would govern actual extraction — remains unfinished. A growing number of countries, including France, Germany, Chile, and several Pacific island states whose own waters would not be touched, have called for a moratorium until the science is clearer. Others, sensing an early-mover advantage, are pressing for the code to be adopted as soon as possible. The decision, when it finally comes, will set a precedent for how humanity treats every other untouched commons on the planet.

7

There is, ultimately, no neutral path. To mine the deep seabed is to accept irreversible damage to an ecosystem we barely understand, in exchange for metals we genuinely need. To leave it alone is to push the burden of supply back onto land, with all the social and environmental costs that brings, and to slow, at least at the margin, the energy transition itself. It is a hard choice, and it is being made now, in committee rooms and contract negotiations, while the rest of us look elsewhere. The next century will live inside the answer we give in the next few years.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says polymetallic nodules look like "potatoes." Explain why the writer chose this particular comparison, and what **effect** it has on the reader. [**2**]

13. Why does the writer describe the nodules as "the slow, patient handiwork of millions of years"? [**2**]

From Paragraph 2

14. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** reasons why mining companies argue that the deep seabed is the best source of these metals. [**2**]

From Paragraph 3

15. The writer says "the seabed... is not a parking lot." Explain, in your own words, what this comparison is meant to reject. [**2**]

16. What does the writer suggest about the **seriousness** of the damage by saying recovery is "measured not in years but in centuries"? [**1**]

From Paragraph 4

17. The sediment plume is compared to "a slow grey snow." Explain why this image is effective in describing the harm done to deep-sea creatures. [**2**]

From Paragraph 5

18. The writer says the International Seabed Authority sits "awkwardly" between the two camps. Using your own words, explain what makes its position awkward. [**2**]

From Paragraph 6

19. The writer says that the seabed already under exploration contract is "larger than the territory of India." What is the **effect** of this comparison? [**1**]

From Paragraph 7

20. The writer says “there is, ultimately, no neutral path.” What does he mean by this? [**2**]

21. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of Text 4? [**1**]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the arguments in favour of mining the deep seabed** and **the arguments against mining it**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 4** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Supporters of deep-sea mining argue that ...

— END OF PAPER —